

Rescuing Refugees

No Nazi barbarity has so shocked Americans as the deliberately expressed intent to exterminate whole classes of people because of their racial or national origin. Many of us were slow to believe that so brutal a purpose could actually be put into practice. Then with horror we beheld the systematic liquidation of Poland's cultural and intellectual leaders, the mass slaughter of Jews regardless of their nationality. There was little enough we could do to arrest these atrocities while the Nazis held their clutch on all of Europe. Whether we did all that we could is a question that must be left to our individual consciences. We did assist in the rescue of some thousands of Hitler's intended victims. And the story of how these rescues were effected is one that casts immeasurable credit upon all who shared in the heroic effort.

The War Refugee Board, created by presidential order in January of this year, has been the official American instrumentality for aid to refugees. It has been resourceful and vigorous in making the pressure of American opinion felt, especially among the Hitler satellite countries; it was effective, for example, in persuading Bulgaria and Romania to revoke their anti-Semitic decrees and to release from internment great numbers of Jewish prisoners. But as its executive director, John W. Pehle, declared in an address the other night, the program of the War Refugee Board "was made possible by generous contributions of suggestions, personnel and funds by private agencies that had already existed in the field of international rescue and relief work."

Mr. Pehle paid particular tribute to the constituent agencies of The United Jewish Appeal. These organizations have carried the main burden of actual rescue operations. They have had splendid support, of course, as Mr. Pehle noted, from many non-Jewish groups and individuals. It is of vital importance that this sort of philanthropy be continued in the future. For the liberation of Europe will simply enlarge the opportunity to give help to Hitler's desolate victims. And they will need help desperately. UNRRA and the Intergovernmental Committee on Refugees will do all that they can, of course, to alleviate general economic conditions. But a great burden of relief and resuscitation must still be shouldered by voluntary charity. The organizations which have carried this burden thus far and are equipped to continue it are represented in the Community War Fund. They deserve the generous support of all who have escaped the Nazis' savagery.